

Mike Blom

Director of Engineering at Instructure — a leader delivering high-confidence roadmaps for multi-team, multi-year platform initiatives.

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Summary

Born a US citizen in the Netherlands, I grew up working every odd job I could find, then moved to the United States alone after high school. I spent over a decade serving with the US Army and Department of State in combat zones around the world, taught myself to write software in 2014, and have spent the years since in education technology — from self-taught engineer at MasteryConnect to Director of Engineering at Instructure, the makers of Canvas. Known for turning ambiguity into clear plans, shipping reliably at scale, and fostering a culture of ownership, collaboration, and continuous improvement.

Leadership philosophy

I lead talented and passionate engineering teams who build and maintain innovative, scalable web applications for online education. My military and government service built foundational skills in communication, de-escalation, reliability, leadership, and ownership — and I apply them daily: overseeing engineering processes, standards, and best practices; ensuring the quality, performance, and security of our products; and mentoring and coaching my team members while fostering a culture of collaboration and innovation. I take pride in delivering intelligent, optimized backends behind smooth, fast frontends. My mission is to empower educators and learners with the tools they need to succeed in the digital age.

Experience

Director of Engineering · Instructure (makers of Canvas)

2019 – present

Leading distributed international engineering teams building scalable web applications for online education.

- Led assessment platform unification, aligning Product, Design, and Engineering on one roadmap
- Scaled distributed international teams, increasing ownership, autonomy, and predictable execution
- Cut projected engineering effort ~70% using high-confidence planning and explicit trade-offs

Engineering Team Lead · MasteryConnect

2014 – 2019

Self-taught engineer who earned a seat through delivery, then kept delivering.

- Highest-volume contributor across 100+ engineers, shipping core production capabilities
- Fast-tracked to Senior Engineer and Team Lead through consistent delivery
- Scaled architecture and features supporting growth through acquisition

Military service

Military and diplomatic service · US Army & US Department of State

2003 – 2014 · Combat zones worldwide, 10+ years

More than ten years in combat zones around the world. A trusted leader in high-risk environments requiring discretion, judgment, and calm execution — safeguarding people, assets, and reputations through communication and de-escalation.

- Leadership and ownership
- Communication and de-escalation
- Reliability under pressure
- Discretion and judgment

Skills

Leadership: Organizational delivery & execution · Technical strategy & architecture · Stakeholder management · Team development & mentorship

Engineering: Scalable modern applications · Data & API platform design · Cloud & infrastructure (AWS, Terraform, CI/CD) · Agentic accelerators & AI features · Ruby on Rails, JavaScript/TypeScript, Node, Nest, Go, React, Angular

Languages: English (native) · Dutch (native) · German (conversational)